

Hackles Teacher Academy: FAQ (20 Teacher Questions)

Trust your hackles. Pause · Check · Tell.

Trust your hackles. Pause · Check · Tell.

FIELD COPY

1



Lock It

PASSWORDS AND ACCOUNTS

2



Spot It

SCAMS AND FAKES

3



Share Smart

PRIVACY

4



Safe People

WHO TO TRUST

5



Kind and Well

KINDNESS AND BALANCE

6



Fix It

TELL, REPAIR, RECOVER

PLATE I. The six strands, hand-inked, in the order the lessons take them.

Hackles · a free kit · quillsup.org

© 2026 Competence Collective. Lesson text and teaching materials: CC BY-NC 4.0 (free to print, share and adapt for non-commercial use with credit). The Hackles name, logos, characters and artwork are not covered by that license: print and share them unaltered for classroom and family use; any other use needs written permission. [VERIFY with counsel]



OCTOBER 2026

Short, honest answers. For longer ones, see the Teacher FAQ (25 Questions) in the Teacher Support Pack.

Hackles · Trust your hackles. Pause · Check · Tell. Hackles · a free kit · quillsup.org. © 2026 Competence Collective. Lesson text and teaching materials: CC BY-NC 4.0 (free to print, share and adapt for non-commercial use with credit). The Hackles name, logos, characters and artwork are not covered by that license: print and share them unaltered for classroom and family use; any other use needs written permission. [VERIFY with counsel]

No student accounts, no student data collected, ever. The Academy follows the same rule for you.

About the Academy

1. I AM NOT A "TECH PERSON." CAN I REALLY DO THIS?

YES. THE ACADEMY IS built for teachers with zero background. Online safety teaching is mostly teaching skills: notice that something feels off, pause, check, tell a trusted adult. If you can listen, stay calm and run a 15-minute activity, you can teach this. You do not need to know the apps. Learn the four patterns (Pressure, Secrecy, The Ask, The Move) and they will outlast every app.

2. HOW LONG WILL IT TAKE?

Quick Start is about 90 minutes. The Full pathway (eight modules) is about 10 hours including the capstone, ideally spread over several weeks (one module a week works well). The Specialist pathway for computing teachers is about 8 hours. Each module takes 60 to 90 minutes if you do the activities and one scenario. Short and spaced beats one marathon.

3. I START TEACHING MONDAY. WHAT IS THE MINIMUM I MUST DO?

Do the **Quick Start**: Module 1 (short version), Module 2 (two activities), Module 4 (five rules), Module 5 (anatomy and a mini micro-teach), Module 6 (the First 10 Minutes card). And before any sensitive lesson, know your counselor's name, your school's reporting contact, and read the First 10 Minutes card. Everything else can follow.

4. DO I NEED A LOGIN, AN ACCOUNT OR A DEVICE TO DO THE ACADEMY?

No accounts, no logins, no tracking. You can work from the printed or digital documents. Activities use paper and invented data. Only a few optional steps (like turning on 2-step verification on your own email, or the Settings Stroll) use your own device, and you never share what you see.

5. IS THE CERTIFICATE OFFICIAL? DOES IT COUNT FOR PD CREDIT?

No. It is awarded on the honor system by a reviewer you choose, and it is not a government or accreditation credential. Some districts may choose to recognize your time for PD: ask your administrator. [VERIFY with your district or state; no credit is guaranteed.]

6. CAN I RUN THE ACADEMY FOR MY WHOLE STAFF?

Yes. It is free to print, share and adapt for non-commercial use with credit (CC BY-NC 4.0 [VERIFY with counsel]). A 90-minute Quick Start in a staff meeting works well, using groups of three for the micro-teach. If you do it, consider becoming a Hackles Mentor.

About teaching

7. WHY ONLY 15 MINUTES? ISN'T THIS SERIOUS ENOUGH FOR MORE?

IT IS SERIOUS, AND that is why it is short, repeated and active. Fifteen minutes fits real timetables, keeps attention, and allows ten lessons across a term. The evidence favors repeated, skill-based lessons over one-off sessions. [VERIFY, Finkelhor et al., 2021] Short lessons also leave room if a child discloses.

8. WHY NOT JUST SHOW A SCARY VIDEO? FEAR GETS ATTENTION.

Fear gets attention for about a minute. Then it tends to fade, or to make telling an adult feel riskier. The evidence on fear appeals is mixed and thin for online safety specifically [VERIFY], but practice tells us that fear without a doable action leaves children anxious or tuned out. Hackles gives children a skill instead: notice, pause, check, tell.

9. A STUDENT KNOWS FAR MORE ABOUT THE APPS THAN I DO. HOW DO I KEEP CREDIBILITY?

Say so, and make it a strength. "You know more than I do. Teach me?" Then move to the patterns that apply to any app: pressure, secrecy, a request, and a move to somewhere more private. Kids respect adults who are honest and curious. Credibility comes from being calm and caring, not from knowing a platform.

10. WHAT IF THE ROLE-PLAY MAKES STUDENTS GIGGLE OR SAY SOMETHING SHOCKING?

Giggling is usually nervous energy. Name it ("A lot of us laugh when things feel awkward") and keep going. If a student says something worrying ("I would just send it"), respond calmly ("Thanks for being honest, lots of people feel that pressure. Let's practice another response") and follow up privately. If anything suggests a child is being pressured or threatened, follow Module 6 and your reporting policy. See Scenario 4.C.

11. HOW DO I TEACH THIS TO 5-YEAR-OLDS WITHOUT SCARING THEM?

Keep it concrete, silly, physical and hopeful. Use a puppet (Hackle), hand signals, a "Helper Hand," and the phrase "I need help." No graphic detail, no mention of "bad people." Say the three promises: a false alarm is fine, it is never your fault, you will not be in trouble for telling.

12. WHAT DO I DO WITH STUDENTS WHO "ALREADY KNOW EVERYTHING"?

Honor their expertise and raise the challenge: make them lead analysts, ask them to write the trickiest fake message, or have them explain the skill to Hackle or to a younger class. Gently add: "Even experts get caught when rushed. That is why we practice a routine." See Scenario 4.B.

About disclosures and reporting

13. WHAT IF A CHILD TELLS ME SOMETHING SERIOUS?

USE THE FIRST 10 Minutes: stay calm; private but visible place; "Thank you for telling me. This is not your fault. You are not in trouble"; open, non-leading prompts only ("tell me more"); be honest that you must tell people whose job is to help; do not view or copy images; report personally and promptly; write down the child's exact words. Keep the Disclosure and Incident Guide handy.

14. CAN I PROMISE A CHILD I WILL KEEP A SECRET?

No. You cannot, and breaking a promise would hurt more. Say: "I can't keep this a secret, because I want to get you help. I will tell you who I am telling." Being honest about limits, kindly, builds trust.

15. DO I HAVE TO REPORT, OR IS TELLING THE PRINCIPAL ENOUGH?

School staff are named as mandated reporters in about 44 states and DC, and a few more states make every adult a reporter. In many states the duty is personal: telling a principal may not by itself satisfy it. The standard is typically that you suspect or have reason to believe a child has been abused or neglected, not proof. Rules, timelines and reporting channels vary by state and district. [VERIFIED 2026-10-05: childwelfare.gov, Mandatory Reporting of Child Abuse and Neglect, current through May 2023; confirm your own state at childwelfare.gov and with your district policy.] If unsure, report or consult CPS or your administrator right away, and do not delay.

16. A STUDENT HAS AN INTIMATE IMAGE OF SOMEONE ON THEIR PHONE. MAY I LOOK AT IT TO SEE WHAT WE'RE DEALING WITH?

No. Do not view, copy, download, forward, print or screenshot suspected intimate images of a minor, and do not ask anyone to send them to you. Under federal law, knowingly possessing or sharing sexual images of a person under 18 is a serious crime and the statute's defenses are narrow, so good intentions are not a safe assumption (state law varies too). [VERIFIED 2026-10-05: 18 U.S.C. 2252A, law.cornell.edu/uscode/text/18/2252A (knowing possession; narrow affirmative defenses); NCMEC advises not forwarding such images, missingkids.org. Confirm with your district counsel how your policy treats school staff and school resource officers.] Secure the device per your policy, tell your administrator, and report as required. Support the child with the three sentences.

17. HOW DO I COPE EMOTIONALLY WITH THESE TOPICS?

Treat it as part of the job to plan for. Debrief with your counselor or administrator the same day; take a break; talk with your own support person without identifying details; use your EAP if you have one [VERIFY]; and remember that if you listened, believed, reported and handed off, you did your job. If you are a survivor yourself, it is fine to ask a colleague to lead sensitive lessons, and playing a child in a role-play is always optional. See Module 6, Part 6.

About families and inclusion

18. A PARENT SAYS I AM "PUTTING IDEAS IN THEIR HEADS." WHAT DO I SAY?

LISTEN FIRST, THEN: "I can tell how much you care. The lessons teach skills such as noticing when something feels off and telling a trusted adult, with no graphic detail. Children already meet these things online; we are giving them tools. I would be glad to share the lesson plan." Offer the counselor and the opt-out process if they prefer. Use the L.E.A.R.N. steps in Module 7. [VERIFY any research you cite]

19. MY STUDENTS HAVE NO DEVICES OR INTERNET AT HOME. WILL THE LESSONS STILL WORK?

Yes. Hackles lessons are unplugged by default (paper, cards, role-play). Make every take-home printable and device-free, never require online access, and do not ask children to "check settings at home" unless a trusted adult can help. Low-internet does not mean low-risk: teach everyone the same skills. See Module 7, Part 5.

About evidence and honesty

20. HOW DO I KNOW THIS WORKS, AND WHAT SHOULD I SAY ABOUT THE STATISTICS?

HONESTLY: WE DO NOT yet have a rigorous trial of a modern K-12 curriculum on topics like sextortion and deepfakes. What we do have is prevention science on active, repeated, skill-based teaching, and the Hackles Assessment Pack for measuring your own class (especially the Tell-Readiness indicator). Quote statistics from primary sources (NCMEC, FBI, Thorn, Pew, CDC, UNICEF) and check them first. Anything in the Academy marked [VERIFY] needs a primary-source check before you print or repeat it. Say "went up" rather than "my lessons caused it."

Still stuck?

- Re-read the relevant module's "Take Action this week."
- Check the Glossary.
- Ask your counselor or a Hackles Mentor in your school.
- Remember the routine, which works for teachers too: **Hackles up? Pause. Check. Tell.** Telling a colleague you are stuck is always okay.

This FAQ is educational guidance, not legal advice. Consult your district policy and counsel on reporting duties in your state.